In the early hours of the next day, 18 July 1980—at 0803 hrs to be precise, India's first Satel ite Launch Vehicle, SLV-3 lifted off from SHAR. At 600 seconds before take-off, I saw the computer displaying data about stage IV giving the required velocity to the Rohini Satel ite (carried as payload) to enter its orbit. Within the next two minutes, Rohini was set into motion in a low earth orbit. I spoke, in the midst of screeching decibels, the most important words I had ever uttered in my life, "Mission Director cal ing al stations. Stand by for an important announcement. Al stages performed to mission requirements. The fourth stage apogee motor has given the required velocity to put Rohini Satel ite into orbit". There were happy cries everywhere. When I came out of the Block House, I was lifted onto the shoulders of my jubilant col eagues and carried in a procession.

The whole nation was excited. India had made its entry into the smal group of nations which possessed satel ite launch capability. Newspapers carried news of the event in their headlines. Radio and television stations aired special programmes. Parliament greeted the achievement with the thumping of desks. It was both the culmination of a national